Pilot Testing and Validity

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What is a Pilot Test?

- A **pilot test** is a **small-scale version** of a full survey that is conducted with a **limited sample size**, usually representative of your target population.
- This "test run" allows you to evaluate the **performance of your survey** before launching it on a larger scale.

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Purpose:

- Uncover problems in survey **design**, **question wording**, or **technology**
- Identify **confusing instructions**, **response options**, or **layout issues**
- Observe **user behavior**, such as skipping questions or taking too long

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Why Pilot Test?

- Understandability
- Clarity
- Timing
- Detecting Bias
- Identifying Missing Elements

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Key Pilot Testing Activities

- Administering the Survey
- Collecting Feedback
- Measuring Completion Time and Dropout Rate

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What is Reliability?

- Reliability refers to the **consistency** or **repeatability** of the survey results.

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Types of Reliability:

- Test-Retest Reliability
- Internal Consistency
- Inter-Rater Reliability

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What is Validity?

- **Validity** is about whether the survey is actually **measuring what it's supposed to measure**.

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Types of Validity:

- Face Validity
- Content Validity
- Construct Validity
- Criterion Validity

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Example

- Do you work out regularly?

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Cognitive Testing

- Cognitive testing is a **pretesting method** used to evaluate whether people **understand survey questions correctly**.

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Cognitive Testing

- Why it matters:
- Even well-written questions can **mean different things** to different people based on:
  - Background
  - Culture
  - Language use
  - Personal experience

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Key Techniques for Cognitive Testing

- Think-Aloud Protocol
- Probing Questions

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Benefits of Cognitive Testing

- Improves clarity
- Reduces confusion
- Improves accuracy
- Increases validity
- Detects unintended meanings

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Improving Response Rates in Surveys

- A **response rate** is the **percentage of people who completed your survey** out of those who were invited to participate.
- **Goal:** Get a high response rate to ensure the data is **representative**, **balanced**, and **valid**.
- **If the response rate is low:**
  - You may miss important groups.
  - It can lead to **nonresponse bias**.
  - The **validity of your conclusions is weakened**.

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Proven Strategies to Increase Survey Responses

- Personalized Invitations
- Incentives
- Keep It Short and Clear
- Communicate Purpose and Privacy

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Summary

- **Pilot Testing** helps catch errors early
- **Reliability** ensures consistency
- **Validity** ensures you're measuring the right thing
- **Cognitive testing** refines question wording
- **High response rates** better quality data

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